

Tools or Teammates? Examining Agency Negotiation in Human-GenAI Collaboration in Creative Work

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Abstract

As Generative AI (GenAI) becomes increasingly integrated into creative work, creative professionals face an emerging dilemma: while GenAI offers powerful capabilities through prompt-based interactions, its automated processes also introduce uncertainties and risks. Drawing on semi-structured interviews with 18 creative professionals, this study examines their experiences and perceptions of integrating GenAI into creative practice. Findings revealed that GenAI's perceived adaptability, creativity, and scalability enhanced the sense of agency in the creative process. Conversely, limitations in transparency, customizability, and feedback mechanisms undermined human agency. These perceptions were influenced by users' conceptualization of GenAI, as either a simple tool or a collaborative partner, and by the folk theories they constructed through iterative communications with the technology. This research advances our understanding of human-machine collaboration in creative fields and provides design implications for developing GenAI tools that more effectively support creative professionals.

Keywords: Generative AI, Human-AI collaboration, agency, transparency, folk theories

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Introduction

The rapidly evolving use of artificial intelligence (AI) is augmenting work collaboration dynamics, shifting the focus from human-to-human interactions to integrated human-machine partnerships (Wang et al., 2020). Generative AI (GenAI), a subset of AI technologies capable of producing new content, ideas, or data in response to user inputs that simulate human-like conversations (Epstein & Hertzmann, 2023), is revolutionizing creative industries (Chui et al., 2023). Creative professionals, in particular, are at the forefront of this transformation, facing unprecedented challenges to their autonomy and expertise due to the rise of GenAI. Through simple prompts, GenAI tools can now perform traditionally human-centric tasks like crafting ad copies, designing campaigns, and generating creative concepts (Chui et al., 2023), fundamentally altering the nature of creative work (Epstein & Hertzmann, 2023). While establishing new efficiencies, this shift introduces concerns about the potential decline of work in creative industries and raises critical questions about the role of creative professionals (Willis, 2023).

The central issue lies in the growing perception that these systems exhibit machine agency, defined as automation with minimal human involvement, which may be seen as a threat to human agency (Sundar, 2020). The evolution of machine agency raises questions about how users balance their trust in AI systems and achieve synergy by negotiating the degree and type of agency delegated to machines. In our study, we conceptualize the “human-GenAI agency tension” as the ongoing negotiation between human expertise and automated processes, where users must balance algorithmic efficiency with human judgment and creativity. This tension manifests in the dynamic interplay between human autonomy and AI system capabilities, where users need to navigate complex decisions about control allocation, trust, and responsibility (Paul et al., 2023). Professionals from the creative industries must regularly negotiate between maintaining their domain knowledge and leveraging AI capabilities while balancing routine and novel creative tasks. Their work inherently requires careful consideration of when and how to use AI tools effectively while preserving human expertise and creative control. Although the concept of machine agency has been discussed, there is limited research on how users navigate the tension between human expertise and automated processes, particularly in contexts where creativity and human judgment are paramount. Thus, this study focuses on creative professionals to understand how humans maintain agency while collaborating with AI in creative work.

In addition, as GenAI tools become more sophisticated, they blur the lines between human and machine roles (Wang et al., 2020). Creative professionals often collaborate with clients, stakeholders, and team members to achieve creative and strategic goals. Traditionally, complex tasks like copywriting, illustration, and video editing are distributed among specialized team members. However, the integration of GenAI is reshaping this dynamic, as GenAI tools can take on multiple roles within a team, such as copywriters or illustrators, reducing reliance on human collaborators and streamlining workflows. While prior research has examined human-AI interaction in structured tasks (Guzman, 2020) and algorithmic systems (Nah, 2023), less attention has been paid to how users navigate the ambiguous boundaries between human and AI contributions in creative collaboration.

To fill these gaps, the research examines how creative professionals perceive GenAI in the context of creative work and how they navigate the challenges associated with its use.

Understanding how users leverage GenAI and navigate the challenges may also highlight its potential to enhance, rather than replace, human creativity.

Human-GenAI Collaboration in Creative Work

The landscape of GenAI tools, such as ChatGPT, has ushered in emergent forms of human-AI interactions, where users can engage with these systems through textual prompts. As these tools become increasingly prevalent, it is crucial to understand how such interactions, not one-shot but continuous usage, may potentially shape user experiences, agency, and creative processes.

The rapid advancement of generative AI tools has fundamentally transformed creative work practices. Early AI systems primarily automated routine tasks, but modern GenAI tools now demonstrate unprecedented capabilities in assimilating information, adapting to contexts, and engaging with users in nuanced ways that exceed earlier AI iterations (Dunn et al., 2023). This evolution represents a significant paradigm shift, particularly in creative industries where AI has become a potential creative and intellectual collaborator (Wang et al., 2020).

Recent studies highlight how AI tools are reshaping creative workflows across industries. Marketing professionals use AI for content ideation and customization (Brüns & Meißner, 2024), and designers leverage programmatic creative platforms to create large-scale personalized advertising (Chen et al., 2019). This shift from tools-as-implements to tools-as-collaborators represents a fundamental change in creative work practices, necessitating new frameworks for understanding human-AI creative collaboration.

Creative work, in particular, is conducive to human-AI collaboration, as it relies on iterative processes where GenAI can support and enhance human creativity (Vaccaro et al., 2024). Creative work involves subjective judgment and refinement, making it a domain where questions of authorship and control are particularly salient. The interpretive nature of these tasks often requires users to negotiate agency with AI systems, balancing AI with their own creative vision. These tensions are heightened by the opacity of AI systems (Gunning et al., 2019), which can complicate collaboration.

Agency Tensions in Human-AI Collaboration

As GenAI systems exhibit capabilities that blur the lines between tool and collaborator, the perception of agency tension becomes a critical area of concern (Sundar, 2020). In this study, we define tools as systems that operate as extensions of user control, carrying out specific tasks as directed. In contrast, teammates are characterized as systems that engage dynamically with users, offering input and collaborating on ideas. On the one hand, AI-powered platforms become increasingly autonomous and act independently, giving rise to “machine agency” (Sundar, 2020). For example, owing to their language-understanding capabilities, GenAI platforms can produce complex outputs based on simple instructions. GenAI can encompass tasks like generating code (Ebert & Louridas, 2023), assisting with creative writing, and even composing music, challenging the concepts of creativity believed to be only human capabilities (Anantrasirichai & Bull, 2022; Magni et al., 2024). Creative professionals often navigate these dynamics as they balance the system’s

capabilities with their expertise, reflecting an ongoing negotiation of the agency. Thus, users might experience enhanced agency through amplifying their creative and intellectual outputs yet face diminished agency as decision-making processes become increasingly autonomous and opaque.

Potential Role(s) of GenAI in Human-AI Collaboration

GenAI supports a range of interactions that are contingent on users' specific tasks and goals. Through fine-tuning prompting strategies, users can achieve their goals and tasks at hand by incorporating additional contextual information, defining tones, or providing specific examples, thus increasing human agency by affecting the AI system's outputs through user inputs, which can potentially serve as information *sources* instead of a medium, from which users passively receive content (E.-J. Lee, 2023).

However, the human-GenAI agency synergy may depend on the role of GenAI. For example, users may apply GenAI tools for lower-complexity tasks like grammar correction and translation to higher-complexity creative endeavors such as music composition and artistic creation (Zhu et al., 2024). The meta-analysis by Vaccaro et al. (2024) highlights that creation tasks, in particular, demonstrate greater potential for achieving human-AI collaboration, as they involve iterative collaboration rather than purely deterministic outputs. The variability in GenAI performance highlights the importance of user perception and interaction with the technology. Different users may exploit the same GenAI capabilities differently, depending on their prompting strategies and objectives (Seeber et al., 2020).

Therefore, the collaboration realization is context-dependent and relies on a person's intentions, capabilities, motivational states, and knowledge (J. L. Davis, 2020). Affordances are not just about material capabilities but also involve user perceptions, interactions, and dynamic interplay in human-machine communication, resulting in "imagined affordances" (Nagy & Neff, 2015). Although technology may direct users toward certain actions, individual appropriation allows for unique uses and interpretations (Norman, 1999). Therefore, we propose the first research question:

RQ1: How do creative professionals perceive and evaluate GenAI's capabilities and limitations in creative tasks?

Negotiating Agency Tensions: The Role of Human Agency

Users actively maintain their agency when working with AI technologies rather than passively accepting AI outputs. By interactively communicating with GenAI systems, as per the action route in HAI-TIME (Sundar, 2020), users exercise agency by strategically evaluating AI outputs, making informed choices based on expertise, and developing creative workarounds for system limitations (Sun et al., 2023). Although users acknowledge AI systems' growing autonomous capabilities, they must also navigate the challenges posed by algorithmic opacity (Burrell, 2016). The black-box nature of AI systems can limit user

control and understanding (Knoth et al., 2024), requiring users to develop deeper knowledge and understanding to effectively optimize their prompts and maintain agency in the collaboration.

When engaging with GenAI platforms, users are not merely interacting with an interface, they are also navigating their preexisting beliefs and assumptions about the technology (Cruz, 2024). Human agency in AI collaboration encompasses a user's ability to make conscious choices about tool usage, evaluate and modify AI outputs based on professional expertise, and develop strategic workarounds for system limitations (Sun et al., 2024). This agency, however, operates within certain constraints, as users must navigate system opacity, technical limitations, and predetermined AI parameters that can restrict their control and understanding. Intuitive understandings, known as *folk theories of technology* (DeVito et al., 2017), can influence how a user perceives and engages with AI systems. Folk theories function as informal, everyday understandings that users develop to make sense of complex or obscure technological functions (DeVito et al., 2017).

Over time, as a user's experiences broaden, these theories evolve, providing them with a dynamic conceptual framework that shapes their expectations, interactions, and behaviors toward AI technologies (Dogruel, 2021). Users form assumptions about how these technologies operate and continuously refine them through testing, enabling them to better understand, anticipate, and manage their interactions with AI systems. For example, a recent study on recruiters using AI to screen candidates demonstrated how users construct and refine folk theories through repeated interactions. The recruiters noted patterns in AI outputs, such as the system favoring certain types of information or formatting, and used these observations to decide when to trust, challenge, or override algorithmic recommendations based on their professional judgment (Cruz, 2024). This evolving understanding may enhance user efficacy and task satisfaction by aligning their perceptions and strategies with the operational realities of AI technologies (Cruz, 2024; DeVito et al., 2017).

Therefore, negotiating with AI platforms is more than just a technical process; it involves drawing on accumulated experiences with the technology to form and enact perceptions that guide interaction. Users' decisions to follow or challenge AI outputs might be influenced as much by their folk theories as by the explicit feedback from the system. Their course of action with GenAI can be thought to be a dynamic process—a fusion of machine outputs, human agency, and underlying beliefs about the technology (Sundar, 2020). Therefore, we ask:

RQ2: How do creative professionals maintain control and overcome the limitations of GenAI?

Methods

Participants and Procedure

To address our research questions, we conducted semi-structured interviews with 18 creative professionals who actively incorporate GenAI tools into their work within the marketing and PR sectors. These individuals integrate GenAI tools, ranging from text

generation software (e.g., OpenAI's GPT models) to image and video generation platforms (e.g., Midjourney, DALL-E, Stable Diffusion) into their everyday professional tasks. The threshold for inclusion in the study required participants to have integrated GenAI tools into their work processes for at least 6 months, ensuring they had prior experience and familiarity with these technologies. Participants were invited to complete a screening questionnaire regarding their professions, whether they had used GenAI tools before, and which tools they currently use.

Interviews were conducted via the Zoom video conferencing platform, allowing participants to share their screens and demonstrate their GenAI work processes in real time. This enabled the collection of visual artifacts like P9's ideation output (Figure 1) and provided a platform for participants to elaborate on their processes with concrete examples of human-AI creative collaboration. The complete interview protocol, including questions about GenAI usage patterns and creative processes, is provided in Appendix A.

Two trained researchers conducted interviews via Zoom meetings, capturing both audio recordings and screen-sharing sessions. All interviews were initially transcribed using Otter.ai transcription software, followed by a verification process where both research team members manually reviewed and corrected transcripts to ensure verbatim accuracy. The interviews were conducted online with Institutional Review Board (IRB) approval. Each participant received a US\$30 Amazon e-gift card upon completing the interview. Detailed participant information is presented in Table 1.

Data Analysis

Three researchers participated in analyzing the data. We used a qualitative data analysis framework (Lotto et al., 1986), which emphasizes iterative coding stages leading to a thematic analysis of the interview data. Our analytical process occurred in three distinct stages: initially, open coding to delineate preliminary categories; subsequently, axial coding to understand relationships among these categories; and finally, theoretical coding to synthesize these relationships to aid in developing a structured theoretical framework.

Open Coding

During the initial open coding phase, we independently conducted a line-by-line review of all transcripts to ensure a granular and comprehensive analysis. Initial codes were applied to participants' responses, frequently using descriptive, verbatim language to capture the authenticity of their perspectives. This process allowed us to identify initial codes that represented participants' experiences, perceptions, and actions. Each transcript was reviewed line-by-line to capture distinct concepts and ideas. For example, the statement "I adjusted my prompt repeatedly to get a more relevant response" was coded as "iterative prompting." Similarly, the quote "It's like working with a teammate who helps me brainstorm" was coded as "anthropomorphizing GenAI." At this stage, codes were kept descriptive and grounded in the data. Examples of initial codes included "efficiency enhancement," "uncertainty in output quality," and "lack of feedback mechanisms." This step resulted in a broad set of codes that captured the diversity of user experiences with GenAI.

TABLE 1
Demographic Information About the Participants

ID	Gender	Title	Country	GenAI Tools	GenAI Use-Cases
P1	Male	Founder	US	ChatGPT	Brand strategy, creative direction
P2	Female	Marketing Manager	US	ChatGPT, MidJourney, DALL-E	Brand strategy, campaign management
P3	Male	Founder	China	ChatGPT	Content creation, storytelling
P4	Female	Marketing Manager	US	ChatGPT, MidJourney, Bing	Brand strategy
P5	Male	PR Specialist	China	ChatGPT, Bard, DALL-E	Graphic design, copywriting, communication strategy
P6	Male	Senior Marketing Manager (B2B)	China	ChatGPT	Brand strategy, campaign management
P7	Male	Digital Marketing Specialist	China	ChatGPT, Leonardo.AI, Tome	Digital content creation
P8	Female	Manager	US	ChatGPT, Firefly	Digital content creation
P9	Male	Digital Artist	China	ChatGPT, MidJourney, Stability.AI	Visual content creation, personal branding
P10	Female	Marketing	US	ChatGPT, Microsoft Copilot	Marketing strategy, copywriting
P11	Female	Product Marketing	US	ChatGPT, MidJourney	Brand storytelling, product messaging, visual content creation
P12	Male	Self-media Practitioner	China	ChatGPT, MidJourney, Firefly	Content creation, digital storytelling
P13	Male	Founder	US	ChatGPT	Creative direction, strategy
P14	Female	Startup Founder	China	ChatGPT	Brand development
P15	Female	Marketing	South Korea	ChatGPT, Claude, MidJourney	Marketing strategy, copywriting
P16	Female	Digital Communication Manager	US	ChatGPT, Microsoft Bing Chat, Bard	Digital strategy, communications planning
P17	Male	Marketing	China	ChatGPT, MidJourney	Marketing strategy, copywriting
P18	Male	Founder and CEO	US	ChatGPT, MidJourney	Marketing strategy, brand development

Axial Coding

The second stage, axial coding, focused on identifying relationships between the initial codes and organizing them into broader categories. This involved grouping related codes under core themes to explore how they interacted. For instance, the codes “iterative prompting” and “developing folk theories” were grouped under the category “strategies to mitigate challenges.” Similarly, the codes “unpredictable responses” and “difficulty in achieving customization” were organized under the category “negative perceptions or challenges.”

Theoretical Coding

The final stage, theoretical coding, integrated the categories identified during axial coding to construct a cohesive theoretical framework. This step focused on understanding the dynamic interplay between user perceptions, challenges, and strategies. For instance, the concept of *agency negotiation* emerged as a central theme, reflecting how users adapted their behaviors and strategies to navigate the perceived constraints of GenAI systems (Kang & Lou, 2022). Theoretical coding revealed the overarching process of agency negotiation through iterative strategies, where users exercised human agency by adapting their interactions with GenAI to address uncertainties and limitations. This framework connected specific actions, such as developing folk theories and refining prompts, to broader patterns of user behavior in navigating GenAI’s affordances and constraints.

To enhance the validity of our coding process and ensure consistent interpretation across researchers, we engaged in thorough and deliberative discussions. Whenever discrepancies in code assignments arose, they were thoroughly debated and discussed until a consensus was reached, ensuring a unified understanding and application of codes.

Findings

By exploring how creative professionals navigate GenAI tools, our findings illuminate a complex relationship between technological affordances and human agency within creative processes. Although concerns about AI’s impact on creative autonomy persist due to uncertainties and lack of control of GenAI’s outputs, our analysis reveals that certain perceived characteristics of GenAI tools enhance human agency in content creation. Our findings identify three key positive perceptions that empower users in their creative work: perceived adaptability, creativity, and scalability.

User Perceptions of GenAI in Creative Work (RQ1)

Positive Perceptions That Contribute to Human Agency

Participants highlighted *perceived adaptability* as a central affordance of GenAI tools, which significantly shaped their creative workflows. This adaptability was characterized by the tools’ capacity to facilitate iterative learning and experimentation, enabling users to refine their approaches and outputs over time. Rather than viewing GenAI as a static resource, participants described it as a dynamic tool that encouraged active engagement and exploration. Participants described how GenAI tools enhanced their ability to control

and adapt creative outputs, fostering a sense of agency in their creative processes. This sense of agency was particularly evident in the iterative nature of prompting, where participants described how they could actively shape the system's outputs. This form of iterative interaction does not merely allow users to refine the AI's responses but also leads to a deeper engagement with GenAI. For example, P1 who is a digital marketer, explains:

Using MidJourney to generate ad campaign copies has been a game-changer for our team. It's fascinating how it learns from our past campaigns and preferences, tailoring the generated content to fit our unique brand voice and target audience. This level of responsiveness is something I haven't seen before. It feels like the tool is not just generating content; it's evolving with us, enhancing our creative process with every interaction.

This quote highlights perceived adaptability by illustrating how users view GenAI as an evolving collaborator that enhances their creative processes. The participant notes an observation about how MidJourney “learns from past campaigns and preferences,” suggesting a sense of iterative improvement and responsiveness to specific needs, such as aligning with their brand voice and target audience. This perception of the tool as dynamic and responsive fosters a sense of agency, as users feel their interactions actively shape the tool's outputs. By emphasizing how the tool “evolves with us,” the quote underscores how adaptability transforms GenAI from a static generator into an iterative partner in the creative workflow.

Similarly, P9 shared his experience when creating ad copy for McDonald's (Figure 1):

Making an ad for McDonald's was fun, but it took a few tries to get it just right. I had to change things and try different ideas to match McDonald's style. It was like a back-and-forth conversation. Every time I changed something, it was like

FIGURE 1
GenAI Generated Image by P9



talking to McDonald's, figuring out what worked best. It's not just me making stuff up; it's like we're working together to make something cool that tells people about McDonald's in a way that feels just right.

This quote reflects perceived adaptability by emphasizing the iterative, collaborative nature of working with GenAI. The participant describes the process of creating an ad as a “back-and-forth conversation,” which highlights the tool's adaptability in allowing users to refine and adjust ideas through multiple interactions. The mention of “trying different ideas” and “changing things” underscores the iterative learning process, where the participant continually adjusts the output to align with McDonald's brand style.

In addition, *perceived creativity* was also frequently reflected by participants. Perceived creativity refers to the extent to which users believe GenAI tools can generate innovative and original ideas that enhance the creative process. This perceived creativity expands users' creative possibilities by offering new, diverse, and often unexpected content options. As a result, users feel empowered to explore a wider range of ideas and solutions, thereby enhancing their perceived agency in creative tasks. For example, participants [P1, P7, P15, P18] highlighted GenAI tools' capability to facilitate users in exploring diverse and novel content options. When using broad preferences as inputs, GenAI tools can generate a range of content suggestions for users to explore and choose from. For instance, P7, a digital marketer, explains how their team employs ChatGPT:

In my current team, we are using ChatGPT to break down tasks. For example, when we need to come up with an ad copy, we might use ChatGPT to do some forward-thinking. It helps us identify different angles and entry points. Sometimes it generates novel ideas that we didn't think of.

This quote reflects perceived creativity by highlighting how users view GenAI tools as a source of innovation that expands their creative possibilities. The participant describes using ChatGPT for “forward-thinking,” which suggests that the tool helps generate new perspectives and ideas that may not have been initially considered. The participant emphasized how the tool enhances creativity by offering unexpected or diverse content options.

Through prompting, participants also appreciate *perceived scalability*, which refers to the extent to which users believe GenAI tools can efficiently handle tasks of varying scope and volume while adapting to diverse creative needs. Participants highlighted that GenAI's ability to scale from producing a single piece of content to thousands per day makes it highly versatile. Additionally, by adjusting prompts, users can generate different versions of content, varying in style, tone, or format, to appeal to broader or more specific audiences. For example, P4, an international marketing manager, shared her experiences in leveraging GenAI to create different versions of product descriptions:

After I compiled some editorials for our gaming apps, I requested ChatGPT to provide me with copy variations. I just asked, ‘Could you generate 10 different copies within these test constraints and suggest possible titles?’ Typically, I receive quite satisfactory outputs, and I then make adjustments to tailor them for

my customer-facing messages. After this, we are rolling out a massive, nationwide campaign needing hundreds of variations.

This quote reflects the perceived scalability of GenAI tools by demonstrating their ability to efficiently handle content generation at both small and large scales. The participant initially uses ChatGPT to “roll out a massive, nationwide campaign needing hundreds of variations,” showcasing how the tool facilitates the rapid production of diverse content variations for immediate needs.

Negative Perceptions That Undermine Human Agency

Participants expressed concerns about the *perceived lack of transparency* in GenAI’s response generation process, which refers to the lack of transparency in how the system processes inputs to produce outputs, making it challenging for users to understand or predict its behavior, leading to frustration in GenAI’s reliability. Such perceived uncertainty potentially undermines the sense of agency and control over the creative process. For example, P11 shared her experience when creating ad copies using Midjourney:

You will never know what you will get; even if you use the same prompts, it (ChatGPT) generates different answers each time. It’s like a ‘Pandora’s box’ and I feel like sometimes it depends on luck. You just need to try multiple times, but you will never know when you can find the best results.

This quote highlights creative professionals’ frustration with the inconsistency and lack of transparency in GenAI’s response generation, which undermines their ability to predict or fully trust the system’s outputs. Similarly, P13 recounted an instance where he instructed ChatGPT to exclude specific terms when drafting a press release, yet those terms still appeared in the final copy—a mistake he warned could cause “serious legal trouble.” Participants frequently expressed concerns about relying solely on GenAI for factual accuracy, particularly in sensitive domains like marketing research [P1, P4, P14] and crafting press releases [P5, P13, P18]. These experiences underscore how the lack of process transparency of GenAI can erode user trust and confidence in its outputs.

Another challenge posed by GenAI, which diminishes human agency, is its *perceived lack of customizability*, which refers to the perceived limitations of GenAI systems in allowing users to tailor their behavior and outputs to align with specific needs, preferences, or domain-specific requirements. While LLMs can generate diverse content by leveraging extensive knowledge bases, this breadth often comes at the expense of depth in specialized areas, restricting user control over the creative process and diminishing their sense of agency. As P18 mentioned:

For instance, when working with law firms, the ad copy needs to be not only engaging but also highly precise, respecting legal terminology and ethical standards. ChatGPT often falls short here, lacking the nuanced understanding required for legal jargon. Similarly, for art galleries, the language needs to evoke a certain aesthetic and emotion, which ChatGPT struggles to capture fully.

This example underscores the challenges stemming from the lack of customizability in GenAI tools, particularly in producing domain-specific content. The participant highlights the inability of ChatGPT to meet the nuanced requirements of industries such as law and art, where precision, emotional resonance, and adherence to specialized standards are crucial. Despite efforts to refine prompts, these limitations are attributed to inherent gaps in the model's training data, which fail to equip it with the expertise needed for such sophisticated demands. This reflects a broader issue where the breadth of GenAI's general knowledge base compromises its depth in specialized contexts, constraining its effectiveness for professional applications.

Participants also perceived a *lack of feedback mechanisms* [P1, P3, P6, P7, P9, P11, P15], which refers to the absence or inadequacy of clear, actionable responses or guidance from GenAI systems that help users refine their inputs and improve results. Despite the presence of feedback features, such as the thumbs-up and thumbs-down buttons in the ChatGPT interface, our participants noted that they either did not notice these feedback options [P1, P3, P4, P12] or had not utilized them [P7, P16, P18]. Even among users who have used it, they found that such a thumbs-up or thumbs-down feedback mechanism itself is unclear regarding its functionality and how it can assist users in improving their results. As P12 mentioned,

It's actually quite tricky to spot, and I'm not really sure if just a single click of feedback would make a noticeable difference in improving the results. Honestly, I would rather go ahead and change my prompts and give it another shot.

Overall, the lack of clear and effective feedback mechanisms in GenAI tools highlights a significant barrier to improving user experience, as it diminishes users' ability to refine and optimize their interactions with the system.

Overcoming GenAI Limitations (RQ2)

Despite the challenges posed by GenAI, our findings reveal that creative professionals employ various strategies to mitigate them, drawing on experiential folk theories and their differing perceptions of GenAI as either a tool or teammate.

Sense-Making of the Opacity: Building Folk Theories of Prompting Mechanisms

The iterative nature of user engagement with GenAI platforms, as described in the experiences of professionals across the creative industries, was salient in the generation of working folk theories of the system's underlying logic. P3, working in PR, explains how he modifies language prompts between English and French based on a working understanding of the system's operational logic:

For example, the logic may be that it first translates the words into French, then translates English into French first, then extracts keywords in French, then summarizes that paragraph into one sentence based on the keywords; if it goes step-by-step like this, I've realized the accuracy is very high.

Participants' interactions with GenAI revealed that their folk theories—informal understandings developed through experience—played a crucial role in refining their use of the technology. Initially, users needed numerous iterations to understand how word placement and choice affected the AI's responses. Over time, as they practiced and observed outcomes, they developed more effective strategies, demonstrating an evolving mastery of GenAI tools. For example, P12 mentioned:

I found that MidJourney's outputs could not capture my instructions to depict a model with a full body, so I made changes and see where the problem was. Is it because the word 'full body' is too far back in the sentence? I guess the earlier a word appears, the more importance the AI places on it, so I arrange my prompts accordingly.

This iterative learning process highlights how users' folk theories guide them in navigating and optimizing their interactions with advanced AI systems.

Leveraging Different Tools to Overcome the Lack of Customizability

Many designers describe how their initial dive into the use of GenAI, such as Midjourney, is often on a steep learning curve. These tools, while providing utility for their work, often require nuanced understanding and specific approaches to achieve desired results. P12, an interaction designer based in China, provides an illustration that describes some of the intricacies faced:

For instance, when creating commercial posters, like for a clothing brand, the human figure and background are generated by Midjourney. But it can't produce a perfect image in one go. I need to split the requirements—generate the model separately, extract it as a transparent base image, and then create a suitable background with the right angles and lighting. If I include detailed descriptions of both the model and background in one prompt, it might not achieve the desired effect. There's also a limitation on the length of prompts.

Anthropomorphizing GenAI in Providing Feedback

The anthropomorphizing of GenAI tools represents a significant adaptation strategy among creative professionals to overcome inherent system limitations, particularly regarding feedback mechanisms. For example, P11, a product marketing professional, described using ChatGPT to develop questions for a new movie theater loyalty program, which did not achieve satisfying results with one simple prompt. To better resolve this, she noted,

I think it is just like communicating with another human colleague. I give ChatGPT instructions step by step, like you would explain this to your colleague, you build on each other's ideas and provide further explanations as needed.

This quote reflects a user-centric approach to providing feedback, in contrast to the engineering-centric design of interface features or mechanisms. By treating GenAI as a

colleague, P11 was able to frame the interaction as an ongoing, dynamic communication, thus compensating for the lack of traditional feedback systems.

Tools or Teammates—Different Perceived Roles of GenAI

In our study, we also found that users developed varying perceptions of the role of GenAI, ranging from a “tool” to an active collaborator or “teammate.” Some participants described GenAI as “an omniscient brainstormer” (P4), “co-designer” (P9), or “a whole editorial team at your fingertips” (P1). These varied perceptions hinge on the degree of user control and the extent of GenAI’s involvement in creative processes. A “tool” operates as an extension of the user’s control, performing tasks based on explicit instructions with minimal autonomy. In contrast, a “teammate” actively participates in the creative process, offering suggestions and engaging in iterative refinement, much like human collaborators.

The quality of outcomes is thus perceived as intertwined with the quality of user interactions, signifying how users, informed by their folk theories, constantly fine-tune their engagement with the AI. While some early users are still learning about GenAI and often engage in simpler tasks that require less creativity, such as translation and providing inspirations for ad copies [P1, P4, P6], more advanced users develop a deeper understanding of various GenAI tools [P9, P13]. This deeper understanding fosters human-AI synergy, allowing these advanced users to become more skillful and augmented by GenAI’s assistance in their creative work. For example, in their process of transitioning into an independent digital artist, P9 experimented with various GenAI tools as he began establishing his own brand. He details: “I have probably generated over 20,000 images up until now, and I would say that I am in the so-called ‘10,000’ club, which is the community formed by highly experienced AI-generated content artists.”

P9 has started to leverage more advanced platforms, such as Stable Diffusion.AI, to enable the creation of uniquely personalized content. This capacity for customization allows for outputs that “can have a strong personal color, which has departed from MidJourney’s own word library and styles.” As one of the pioneers to garner attention from major brands like McDonald’s, he has since collaborated with numerous well-known companies to create advertising campaigns generated by GenAI. In these instances, P9 viewed GenAI not as a passive tool but as a collaborative partner contributing creatively to his projects. However, when these platforms did not meet his expectations, professionals like P9 and P13 adapted by pivoting to other tools, such as Photoshop. This adaptability reflects the ability of advanced users to fluidly transition between using GenAI as a “teammate” and as a “tool” depending on the context and needs. This distinction between tools and teammates reflects how user expectations and engagement influence the perceived role of GenAI. When GenAI is viewed as a tool, its utility lies in efficiency and automation, making it indispensable for routine or structured tasks. When seen as a teammate, its value shifts toward collaboration, with users integrating its suggestions into a shared cognitive workflow that amplifies creativity and problem-solving capabilities. Recognizing these roles helps illustrate the spectrum of human-AI collaboration, from automation to synergistic partnership.

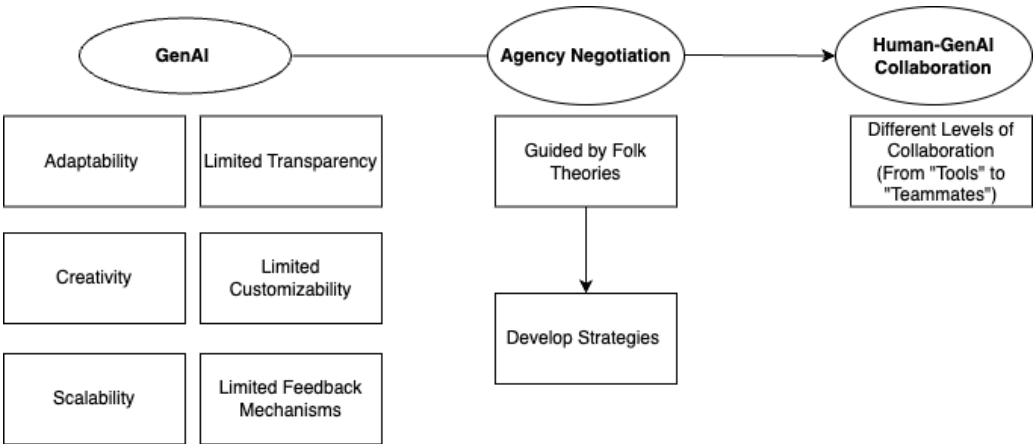
TABLE 2
Key Concepts and Their Definitions in This Study

Positive Perceptions Enhancing Human Agency		
GenAI Perceptions	Definition	Example
Perceived Adaptability	The extent to which users believe GenAI tools can learn and adjust their outputs based on interactions and feedback, enabling iterative improvement and experimentation	It learns from past campaigns and preferences, tailoring generated content to fit specific brand voice and target audience
Perceived Creativity	The extent to which users believe GenAI tools can generate innovative and original ideas that enhance the creative process	Generate novel ideas for content creation or for brainstorming
Perceived Scalability	The extent to which users believe GenAI tools can efficiently handle tasks of varying scope and volume while adapting to diverse creative needs	Creating multiple versions of product descriptions at different scales, from single pieces to thousands of content pieces per day with variations in style, tone, and format
Negative Perceptions Undermining Human Agency		
GenAI Perceptions	Definition	Example
Perceived Lack of Transparency	The lack of transparency in how the system processes inputs to produce outputs, making it difficult for users to understand or predict system behavior	Using the same prompt in Midjourney can generate quite different results that are hard to predict, similar to opening a <i>pandora box</i>
Perceived Lack of Customizability	The perceived limitations of GenAI systems in allowing users to tailor their behavior and outputs to align with specific needs, preferences, or domain-specific requirements	When creating ad copy for law firms, ChatGPT struggles with precise legal terminology and ethical standards due to the limitation of training data of GenAI
Lack of Feedback Mechanisms	The absence or inadequacy of clear, actionable responses or guidance from GenAI systems that help users refine their inputs and improve results	Basic feedback features like thumbs-up and thumbs-down buttons in ChatGPT interface are present but insufficient for meaningful guidance

Discussion

This study explores the nuanced ways in which creative professionals navigate and optimize their interactions with GenAI tools. By examining perceived affordances, limitations, and user strategies, we offer insights into how creative professionals communicate with and collaborate alongside GenAI. Our findings highlight both positive and negative perceptions of GenAI’s impact on human agency in creative work. Furthermore, the interplay between human agency, folk theories, and anthropomorphism plays a critical role in shaping the strategies that creative professionals employ to overcome challenges. The study proposes a theoretical model that identifies key perceptions enabling GenAI agency and outlines how users negotiate agency tensions (Figure 2). This framework provides valuable preliminary insights for future research into the underlying psychological mechanisms that govern human-AI collaboration.

FIGURE 2
Conceptual Framework Explicating Human-GenAI Agency Negotiation in Creative Work



GenAI as a Double-Edged Sword for Creative Work

Our study illustrates how interacting through the same interface of GenAI tools through prompting can lead to a diverse and complex array of user perceptions (Knoth et al., 2024), highlighting the varied user experiences with these technologies. As Knoth et al. observe, identical interfaces can generate remarkably diverse user perceptions and experiences. This phenomenon aligns with the notion of “perceived affordances” (Norman, 1999), where the perceived possibilities for action are shaped not just by the interface design but by users’ experiences, knowledge, and cultural context. While perceived adaptability, creativity, and scalability of GenAI were perceived as enabling human agency, lack of customizability, transparency, and feedback mechanisms negatively affect user control in the creative work.

The *perceived adaptability* of GenAI tools gains particular significance in creative work contexts, where iterative refinement is fundamental to the creative process (Lubart, 2001). The perceived adaptability of GenAI tools can be analyzed through the theoretical lenses

of contingency theory and message interactivity (Sundar et al., 2016). When users perceive they can *influence* outputs through prompt adjustments, it creates a contingent interaction pattern where system responses are seen as directly dependent on user inputs. Future research may examine how perceived adaptability may influence user trust in GenAI outputs through triggering *helper heuristic* (S. Lee et al., 2023) and contingency.

The *perceived creativity* pushes forward the discourse on the role of AI in the creative process. Traditionally, computational creativity has focused on the ability of computers to produce work that is traditionally considered creative if produced by humans (N. Davis, 2013). However, the creative potential of GenAI introduces a new dimension in which AI acts not only as a creator but also as a facilitator and enhancer of human creativity. Our study highlights how users engage with and explore new content, contributing to the growing body of literature on human-AI co-creativity (Du et al., 2024). Given the recent pushback surrounding AI's involvement in creative work (Magni et al., 2024; Willis, 2023), further research is essential to examine user perceptions of GenAI's creativity and to explore the evolving conceptualizations of creativity in the era of GenAI (Sundar & Liao, 2023).

Finally, the *perceived scalability* significantly impacts operational efficiency and capacity in the digital realm. Essentially, GenAI tools can generate a vast amount of content quickly and accurately, adapting to various contexts and needs. This capability not only streamlines the production process but also enhances the ability to meet growing content demands across multiple platforms and formats (Liu-Thompkins et al., 2020). As a result, scalability not only optimizes the creation cycle but also expands the potential for reaching larger and more diverse audiences (Campbell, 2023). However, our study only reflects the content creators' perspectives, how other consumers or other stakeholders perceive such content created by GenAI requires future research. For instance, recent research has indicated that people tend to perceive GenAI as exerting less effort than humans in the creation of a given artifact, leading to lower creativity ratings for outputs produced by AI (Magni et al., 2024).

The negative aspects of GenAI, as revealed in our study, echo previous research regarding the tension between automation and user control (Kaur & Rampersad, 2018; Simmler & Frischknecht, 2021). The findings also extend the HCI literature of explainable AI (XAI; Gunning et al., 2019) into the GenAI context, by revealing the user perceptions of lacking transparency affordance of GenAI platforms. The opacity of AI models has worsened the situation for GenAI, although recent efforts have been devoted to making GenAI models explainable (Raees et al., 2024). Without transparency of the outputs, our participants rely on their own understanding, or folk theories, to navigate the challenges they encountered during content creation with GenAI.

The Role of Folk Theories in Agency Negotiation

As the current GenAI tools are very opaque in their curation algorithms, users often rely on their experiences and develop folk theories to influence and exercise their agency over uncertain outcomes. Previous research has cautioned that inaccurate folk theories, or the gaps between users' false beliefs and designers' intentions, can be harmful and lead to misuse or distrust (Jakesch et al., 2019). In our study, we found that folk theories can be effective in helping users navigate opacity and uncertainties. Specifically, when confronted

with highly uncertain outcomes, users developed diverse prompting strategies based on their observations and experimentation. Through iterative testing, they identified the most effective prompting techniques for their specific needs. Such findings correspond with previous research on folk theories, especially in the context of opaque algorithmic-driven platforms such as social media content curation (DeVito et al., 2017; Toff & Nielsen, 2018).

Effects of Anthropomorphism of GenAI

Our findings reveal how users' perceptions of GenAI evolve from viewing it as a tool to treating it as a collaborative partner. The anthropomorphism tendency in large language models echoes the recent work by Cohn et al. (2024). These findings demonstrate the value of examining the CASA (Computers Are Social Actors) paradigm (Nass et al., 1994) in the GenAI context. Our study found that it is possible for creative users to naturally apply social and collaborative responses to computer interactions, treating GenAI "tools" as "teammates" (Nass et al., 1996). In addition, the evolution from command-response interactions to conversational engagement with GenAI marks a significant shift in human-machine communication patterns. When users reconceptualize AI as a collaborative partner rather than a mere tool, they develop more sophisticated interaction strategies that move beyond simple instruction-output paradigms. This transformation not only reflects an increased sense of agency in users' creative processes but also points to a redefined role for GenAI in creative industries. This shift opens new research avenues of human-machine interaction dynamics for co-creativity between humans and machines.

Practical Implications

Our study holds practical implications for both GenAI platform designers and creative practitioners. Central to effective design is the balance between enhancing perceived adaptability and reducing uncertainty. Interfaces should provide transparency in AI processing and decision-making while enabling customization for different professional contexts. This transparency becomes particularly crucial in creative fields where outcomes directly impact brand identity and client relationships. The design should support iterative refinement processes and facilitate seamless transitions between human and AI contributions, allowing for flexible scaling of AI assistance based on task complexity.

In addition, this study provides valuable insights for creative professionals seeking to effectively integrate GenAI into their workflow strategies for overcoming challenges and offer practical frameworks for implementation. Moreover, the study demonstrates how different perceptions of GenAI can lead to more sophisticated interaction patterns that enhance creative outcomes. These insights encourage professionals to rethink their relationship with GenAI, moving beyond basic prompt-response patterns to develop more nuanced collaborative approaches that leverage both human expertise and AI capabilities.

Limitations and Future Research

Several limitations may shed light on future research. First, our study primarily encompasses participants from the advertising and marketing industries, with GenAI predominantly employed for marketing purposes. While our findings provide valuable insights into

GenAI's practical applications within specific fields, it is important to recognize potential limitations in their generalizability to other domains. Future research should explore these findings in broader contexts where balancing human autonomy with AI capabilities is equally critical, such as journalism (Pavlik, 2023) and academic writing (Lund et al., 2023). Second, the voluntary nature of participation in our study may introduce self-selection bias as consenting participants may represent more active and advanced GenAI users within the advertising and marketing sectors. This warrants future research attention regarding users who are reluctant to adopt GenAI and the impact of GenAI literacy (Cardon et al., 2023).

Conclusion

Through semi-structured interviews, our study delves into the intricate negotiation of agency between creative professionals and GenAI. The results highlight the role of positive perceptions of what GenAI can afford users in enhancing user agency and negative ones in undermining agency. Furthermore, by exploring how users exercise human agency through strategies guided by their folk theories, the study contributes to a more thorough understanding of agency dynamics in human-machine communication. The evolution from viewing GenAI as a tool to treating it as a collaborative partner suggests a more sophisticated understanding of human-machine agency distribution. The findings shed light on the evolving dynamics of human-machine collaboration and hold design implications for both GenAI developers and creative practitioners.

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APPENDIX A

Interview Protocol

Research Objective: To examine how creative professionals perceive and interact with Generative AI tools, focusing on agency negotiation and folk theories development.

Participant Demographics

- ▶ Professional background
- ▶ Duration of GenAI experience
- ▶ Primary creative responsibilities

Tool Engagement and Implementation

1. Current GenAI tool utilization
 - ▶ “How frequently do you use GenAI tools in your workflow, and in what specific contexts?”
 - ▶ “What criteria do you use when deciding which GenAI tool to use for a particular task?”
 - ▶ “Could you describe how you’ve integrated GenAI tools into your existing creative workflow?”
2. Process Documentation
 - ▶ “Would you be willing to share your screen and walk me through a recent project where you used GenAI tools?”
 - ▶ “Can you demonstrate how you typically interact with [specific tool] when working on a creative task?”
 - ▶ “Do you have examples of outputs from different iterations of prompts you could share with us?”

Agency and Control

1. Decision-making processes
 - ▶ “How do you decide when to use GenAI tools versus traditional methods in your creative process?”
 - ▶ “What strategies do you use to allocate tasks between yourself and GenAI tools?”
 - ▶ “What quality control mechanisms have you developed to evaluate and verify GenAI outputs?”
-

2. Creative autonomy
 - ▶ “Could you walk me through your process of developing effective prompts for GenAI tools?”
 - ▶ “How do you typically modify or refine the outputs generated by these tools?”
 - ▶ “What techniques have you developed to ensure brand consistency when using GenAI-generated content?”

Limitations and Adaptations

1. Technical constraints
 - ▶ “What limitations or constraints have you encountered when using GenAI tools in your creative work?”
 - ▶ “Can you describe any workarounds you’ve developed to overcome these limitations?”
 - ▶ “What strategies have you found most effective for optimizing GenAI outputs?”
2. Folk theory development
 - ▶ “How has your understanding of what GenAI tools can and cannot do evolved over time?”

Professional Impact

1. Workflow transformation
 - ▶ “In what ways has incorporating GenAI tools changed your efficiency or productivity?”
 - ▶ “How has your professional role evolved since you began using GenAI tools?”

Note: Semi-structured interview format allowed for the organic exploration of emergent themes while maintaining systematic data collection.

Duration: 45–60 minutes

Recording: Audio and screen recording with participant consent
